

06

Headline Formulas and the Swipe File

Document 6 of 8

If you're new to this series, start with ****What a Headline Actually Does****.

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Formulas Are Training Wheels, Not the Bike

The internet is full of lists — "283 headline templates," "100+ fill-in-the-blank formulas." They exist because formulas genuinely work: each one is the fossil of a psychological pattern that pulled response for decades, compressed into a reusable shape. But copy your formulas mechanically and your headlines will read mechanically, because the reader has seen the skeleton before too.

The right relationship with formulas is the one a musician has with scales. You practice them until the *patterns underneath* — the benefit promise, the curiosity gap, the warning, the proof signal — become instinct. Then you stop playing scales in public. A formula is a starting scaffold for a draft and a diagnostic lens for reading great ads, never a finished headline.

This document gives you the small set of master formulas worth internalizing, teaches you *why* each works (so you can bend it), and shows you how to build the tool that eventually replaces all lists: your own swipe file.

The Master Formulas

1. How to [Achieve Desirable Outcome]. The most durable opening in advertising. "How to" makes an implicit contract: read this, and you'll come away *able to do something you couldn't before*. It converts a claim into an offer of instruction — nobody argues with a lesson. Strengthen it by attaching the benefit's edges: "How to Win Friends and Influence People" (the title Dale Carnegie made famous) works because both halves are things the reader deeply wants and privately doubts they're good at. Variants: "How to [outcome] without [dreaded cost]," "How to [outcome] even if [disqualifier]."

2. Who Else Wants [Desirable Outcome]? The hidden engine is the word *else* — it presupposes a crowd already getting the outcome, so the headline is simultaneously a benefit promise and social proof. "Who Else Wants a Screen-Star Figure?" isn't asking whether the outcome is possible; that's settled. It's only asking whether *you're* joining.

3. [Do/Have You] Make These Mistakes in [Subject]? The warning formula, immortalized by the famous "Do You Make These Mistakes in English?" — one of the longest-running ads in history. The magic word is *these*: it points at specific mistakes you can't see yet, welding fear of error to a curiosity gap. The reader clicks not to buy, but to check themselves.

4. Give Me [Short Time] and I'll [Deliver Outcome]. A dramatized bargain: a tiny, concrete commitment traded for a large, concrete result. "Give Me Five Days and I'll Give You a Magnetic Personality." The formula works because it prices the reader's risk in *time*, which feels safer to spend than money — and the speaker's confidence is itself a proof signal.

5. They Laughed When [Low-Status Moment] — But When [Turn]! The story formula (see **Finding Your Angle**): humiliation, pivot, implied triumph, cut off at the peak. Use it whenever your product creates a visible before/after that others witness.

6. Warning: [Danger Relevant to Reader]. The pattern-interrupt. "Warning" is one of the few words that borrows institutional authority — it's the vocabulary of safety labels, not salesmen. Must be followed by a danger the body copy genuinely substantiates, or the borrowed authority converts to broken trust.

7. The Secret of [Desirable Outcome]. Pure mechanism-tease (see **Curiosity: Withholding the How**): asserts a specific piece of withheld knowledge stands between the reader and the outcome. "The Secret of Making People Like You." Wears out fastest of all the formulas — "secret" is heavily spent vocabulary — so it demands an unusually fresh subject.

8. [Number] Ways to [Outcome] / [Number] Mistakes That [Cost]. The list formula. The number makes the promise concrete and finite (a known, skimmable commitment), and odd or specific numbers out-pull round ones ("76 Reasons Why It Would Have Paid You..." — see **Believability and Proof**).

9. At Last / Announcing / New: [Development]. The news formula. Frames the product as an event, and gives the long-suffering reader permission to hope again — "at last" implies the wait (and their past failures) weren't their fault.

Notice what the nine reduce to: benefit, social proof, warning, bargain, story, curiosity, specificity, news. That's the real lesson. When you can name the pattern under a formula, you can write headlines that follow no formula at all.

The Swipe File: Your Real Education

A **swipe file** is a personal, organized collection of proven advertising you study — the working copywriter's textbook. Every master kept one. The reasoning is blunt: headlines that ran for years in paid media *ran because they were paying*. A famous control that survived a decade of testing contains more verified persuasion knowledge than any theory book.

Collect. Save ads you see repeatedly over weeks or months — repetition in paid media is the signal that something is working. Save classics (the ads quoted throughout this series are the start of a canon). Save headlines that stopped *you*, even outside your market; your own reaction is data.

Organize by pattern, not by product. File by which principle a headline runs on — benefit lead, curiosity gap, warning, proof-heavy, story — and note which of the three surfaces it lived on. A swipe file sorted by industry teaches you what other niches say; sorted by pattern, it teaches you how persuasion works.

Study, don't skim. For each keeper, annotate the same three questions used throughout this series: *Anatomy* (what parts is it built from?), *Why It Works* (which psychological pattern carries it?), *Funnel Fit* (which surface, which commitment?). Ten headlines analyzed this way teach more than a thousand collected.

Swipe the structure, never the words. This is the ethical and practical line. Copying a headline verbatim is theft, and it also doesn't work — the original was calibrated to its market, moment, and product. What you take is the *skeleton*: the mistake-tease of "Do You Make These Mistakes...", the time-bargain of "Give Me Five Days..." — re-fleshed entirely with your market's specifics. If someone who knows the original would call yours a copy, you've swiped too shallow.

Three Classic Swipes, Annotated

SWIPE

"Do You Make These Mistakes in English?" (a famous classic that ran for decades)

ANATOMY [Direct Question] + ["These" Pointing at Unseen Specifics] + [Everyday Competence Area].

WHY IT WORKS It weaponizes self-doubt about a skill everyone uses publicly every day, and "these" creates a gap only the copy can close. The reader self-tests; the ad merely holds the mirror. Decades of paid repetition are the proof it kept working.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — a self-check question is a one-second, high-relevance scroll-stopper.

SWIPE

"How to Win Friends and Influence People" (Dale Carnegie's title — perhaps the most successful "how to" ever)

ANATOMY [How To] + [Deep Social Desire] + [Second Compounding Desire].

WHY IT WORKS Two universal wants — belonging and influence — joined so naturally the reader hears one seamless promise. There's no cleverness, no curiosity trick, no adjectives: just instruction offered toward outcomes nearly every human privately wants more of. Proof that at maximum benefit-clarity, plain beats clever.

FUNNEL FIT Advertorial — "how to" promises an education, which is what an editorial read delivers.

SWIPE

"Who Else Wants a Screen-Star Figure?" (a famous classic)

ANATOMY [Who Else] + [Vivid Aspirational Image].

WHY IT WORKS "Else" smuggles in a crowd of satisfied users without citing one, and "screen-star figure" is a benefit the reader can see rather than parse. Question form makes the reader answer — and a "yes, me" is the click.

FUNNEL FIT Ad — self-selecting question, instant image, zero explanation needed.

Fictional Before/After: Filling a Formula vs. Wearing It

Imagine you're promoting a fictional posture-training wearable, the AlignBand.

Before (formula filled mechanically):

How to Fix Your Posture Fast!

Technically a "how to." But the blank was filled with generic category words — "fix," "fast" — so the skeleton shows through and reads as advertising wallpaper.

After (same formula, market-calibrated flesh):

How Desk Workers Are Undoing 'Laptop Hunch' — Without Exercises, Reminders, or a Single Chiropractor Visit

Still the "how to" pattern (with the "without [dreaded cost]" variant). But now it's fleshed with the audience (desk workers), a named, recognizable pain ("laptop hunch"), and negations of the three fixes the reader has already tried and abandoned. The formula gave the draft its shape; the market gave it its words.

■ Calibrating Formulas Across the Three Surfaces

Formulas are surface-agnostic skeletons — the calibration is in which you reach for, and how loudly.

- **Ad — question, warning, and news skeletons.** Cold readers respond to self-check questions ("Do You Make These Mistakes..."), warnings, and news frames — the formulas that read as content, not commerce. Keep the fill editorial and platform-clean.
- **Advertorial — story and "how to" skeletons.** The read is best sold by formulas that promise narrative or instruction: "They Laughed When...", "How to...", "The Secret of..." — shapes that a long editorial page can actually deliver on.
- **Jump page — bargain and promise skeletons.** This is a second ad for a one-click reader, so reach for compressed, confident structures that still sell: "Give Me [90 Seconds] and I'll Show You..." pointed straight at the play button — a time-bargain plus the loop the ad opened, aimed at the video. Keep the curiosity the reader arrived with; just don't open a new, unrelated mystery.

✓ Key Takeaways

- Formulas are fossilized psychology: learn them to internalize the patterns (benefit, proof, warning, bargain, story, curiosity, specificity, news), then outgrow them.
- Master the nine skeletons — from "How to..." and "Who Else Wants..." to the warning, the time-bargain, and the numbered list.
- Build a swipe file: collect ads proven by paid repetition, organize by pattern and surface, and annotate each with Anatomy / Why It Works / Funnel Fit.
- Swipe the structure, never the words — refill every skeleton with your market's specific audience, pain, and mechanism.

- Match skeleton to surface: content-like shapes at the ad, narrative and instruction shapes at the advertorial, compressed bargain-and-promise shapes at the jump page.